Plugin Shelf for REAPER

User Guide



Emelowsky

Document version 2.2 (Plugin Shelf 3.7.94, Override 2.4)

Introduction — Why Plugin Shelf for REAPER

REAPER's native plugin browser isn't actually lacking in features — it lets you create your own folders, load presets, save FX chains. The problem isn't missing functionality. The problem is that it's still a **text list**. To find a plugin, you have to remember its name — and that's not always what you actually remember.

Because some of us are visual thinkers. We remember what that compressor's panel looked like, what color it was, what the knobs looked like — but not necessarily what it was actually called. With dozens or hundreds of plugins, reading through line after line of text to spot “the one I mean” is slower and more tiring than it should be — especially since the eye recognizes an image far faster than it processes a name.

That was the main reason Plugin Shelf exists: turn searching by name into searching by look. Every plugin has its own icon — you see the tile and instantly know what it is, without reading. On top of that came things that make everyday work easier too — your own categories, fast search, building chains in a few clicks, a shortcut for instant switching — but all of that adds up to serve one main goal: recognizing your tools by eye, not by reading.

This manual walks you through everything, from installation to the smallest appearance settings — you don't need to read it cover to cover. Treat it as a reference: come back to a specific chapter when you need something, or skim through it once to see everything the script can do.

The script is still under active development — if something isn't working as it should, or you're missing a feature, let us know.

Table of Contents

1. Requirements and installation

2. First launch and license activation

3. Main window — overview

4. Categories

4b. Automatic categories

5. Adding plugins

6. Tags

7. Search and “Most used”

8. Notes, hiding, undoing deletion

9. Bulk actions

10. Factory presets

11. FX chains

12. Quick Switch

13. Window ON/OFF shortcut

14. Options panel — visual customization

14b. Maintenance

15. Backups, exporting and importing settings

16. Demo version — limitations

17. Troubleshooting

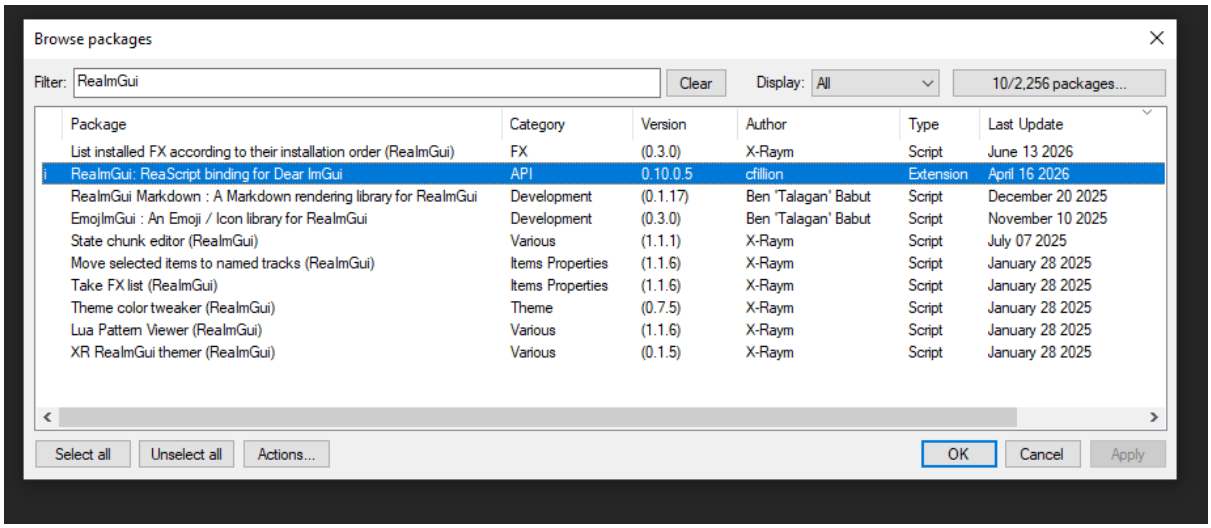
1. Requirements and installation

Plugin Shelf is a REAPER script written in Lua, using ReaImGui — a free extension for building interfaces. Before running the script, make sure you have installed:

- REAPER 7 (latest stable version recommended) or REAPER 6 — on REAPER 6 use the files from the "Lua 5.3 (REAPER 6)" folder of the package (details in "Plugin Shelf for REAPER - REAPER 6 (Lua 5.3) PLEN.txt")
- The ReaImGui extension — installed via ReaPack
- (Optional) the js_ReaScriptAPI extension — installed via ReaPack, needed only for creating icons from a screen capture (chapter 5)

Installing ReaImGui via ReaPack

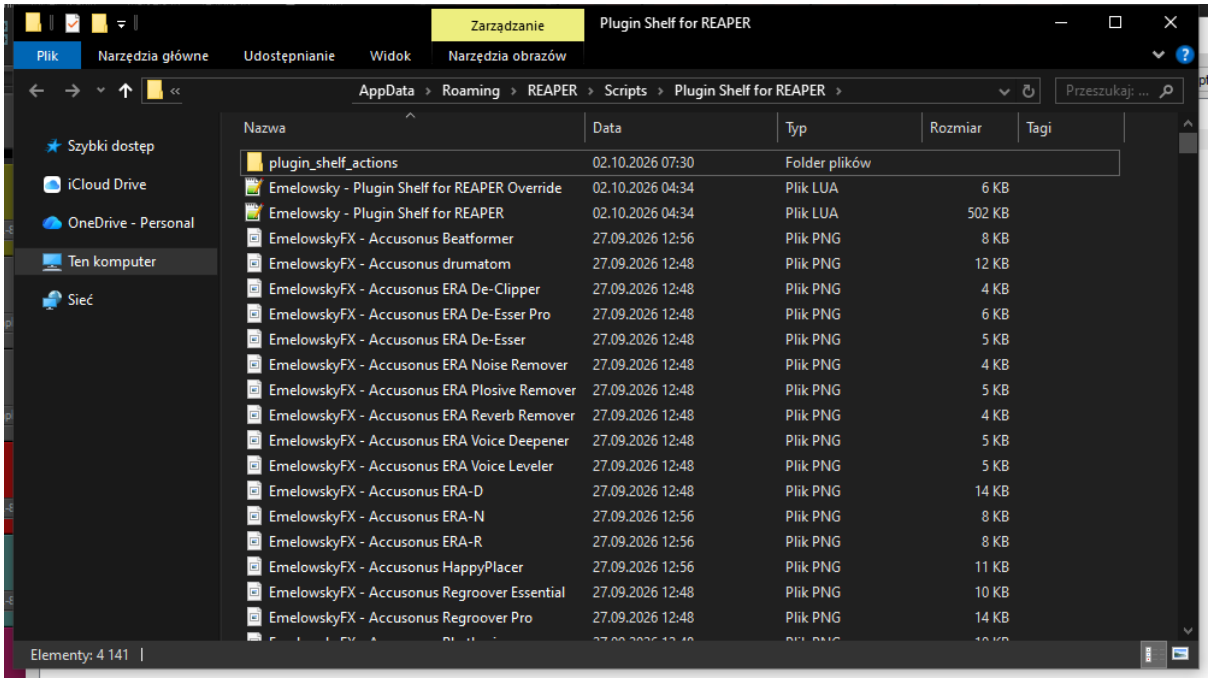
1. If you don't have ReaPack yet — download it from reapack.com and install it following the instructions on the site.
2. In REAPER: Extensions → ReaPack → Browse packages.
3. Search for "ReaImGui".
4. Right-click the result → Install.
5. Confirm (Apply) and restart REAPER.



Installing the Plugin Shelf script

1. Copy the .lua file you received into the Scripts/Plugin Shelf for REAPER folder inside REAPER's resource path (open it from the top menu: **Options → Show REAPER resource path in explorer/finder**).

   (If the Plugin Shelf for REAPER subfolder doesn't exist yet inside Scripts, create it manually.)



2. Unzip the icons from “Emelowsky - Plugin Shelf for REAPER (icons).zip” DIRECTLY into that same Scripts/Plugin Shelf for REAPER folder, next to the .lua file — NOT into a separate “Icons” subfolder. All the .png files (over 4000 of them, e.g. “EmelowskyFX - Plugin Name.png”) must sit at the same level as the script itself.

   (If the icons end up in a subfolder, the script won't find them and the tiles will show plugin names instead of pictures.)

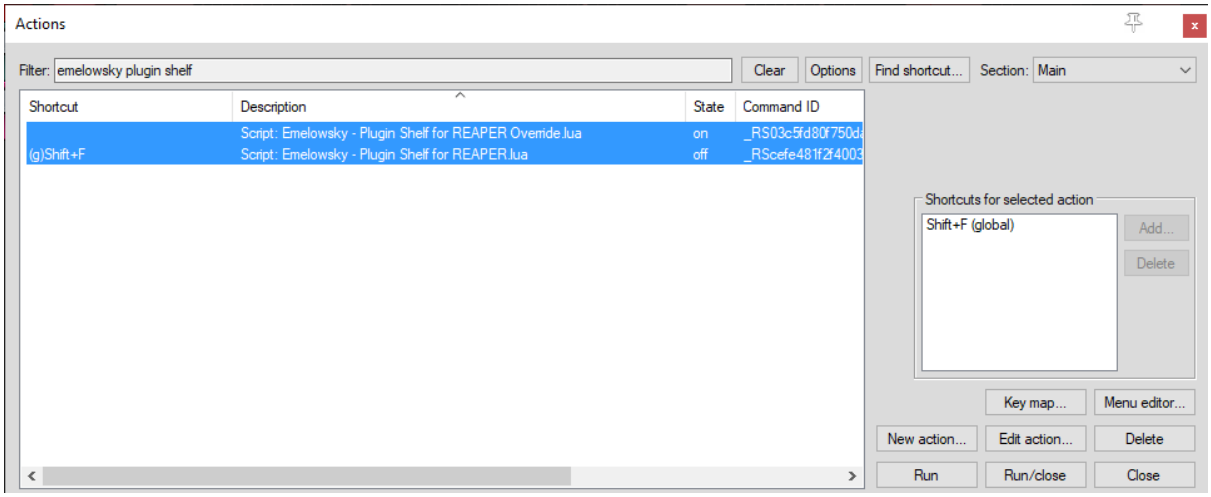
3. In REAPER: Actions → Show action list.
4. Click New action... → Load ReaScript...
5. Point it to the copied .lua file.
6. The script will appear in the action list — you can run it from there or assign it a keyboard shortcut.

Installing with ReaPack (instead of copying by hand)

You can also install Plugin Shelf with ReaPack — updates then arrive by themselves (Extensions → ReaPack → Synchronize packages).

1. Extensions → ReaPack → Import repositories… and paste: https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Emelowsky/reapack/main/index.xml
2. Extensions → ReaPack → Browse packages… → search for “Plugin Shelf” → tick “Emelowsky - Plugin Shelf for REAPER” and “Emelowsky - Plugin Shelf for REAPER (icon pack)” (icons) → Install → Apply.
3. Note — different folder: ReaPack installs everything into Scripts/Emelowsky/Plugin Shelf for REAPER (with an extra “Emelowsky” folder), not Scripts/Plugin Shelf for REAPER as in the manual install. The icons go there automatically — nothing to unzip.
4. ReaPack adds both actions (Plugin Shelf and Override) to the Action List for you — skip steps 3–6 above.

Pick one way of installing. The manual copy and the ReaPack copy are two separate scripts with separate data (each has its own shelf). When you move to ReaPack, copy user_plugins_3.x.lua from the old folder to the new one while Plugin Shelf is closed. The license, the categories wizard and the toolbar icon (from the shop download) work the same way.

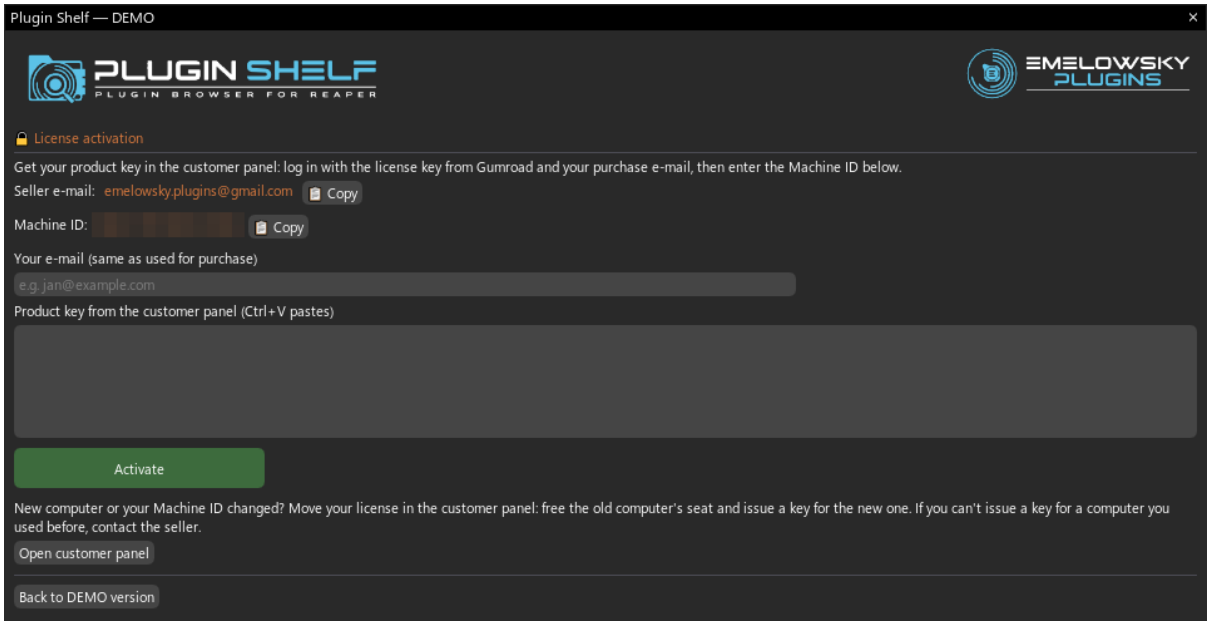

Actions
Filter: emelowsky plugin shelf
Clear
Options
Find shortcut...
Section: Main
Shortcut
Description
State
Command ID
Script: Emelowsky - Plugin Shelf for REAPER Override.lua
on
(g)Shift+F
Script: Emelowsky - Plugin Shelf for REAPER.lua
off
Shortcuts for selected action
Shift+F (global)
Add...
Delete
Key map...
Menu editor...
New action...
Edit action...
Delete
Run
Run/close
Close

Only one copy runs at a time (new in version 3.7.94): if Plugin Shelf is already running from another folder — e.g. an old manual copy next to the ReaPack one — the second copy does not start and tells you so. Close the other copy, or better, delete the old manual copy (and its actions / toolbar button) and restart REAPER.

2. First launch and license activation

Without an active license, Plugin Shelf runs as the demo version (limitations — chapter 16). To unlock the full version, click the “I have a key - activate” button in the top-right corner of the window, next to the DEMO VERSION label — the license activation screen opens. The “Back to DEMO version” button at the bottom of that screen closes it without activating.





Step by step

1. Copy the Machine ID shown on screen (the “Copy (Machine ID)” button).
2. Click “Open customer panel” and log in with the license key from Gumroad (it came by email after your purchase) and the email address used at purchase.
3. Enter the Machine ID in the panel — the panel issues a **product key** (a long string of characters). This is not the Gumroad key: that one is only for logging in to the panel.
4. Paste the whole product key into the “Product key from the customer panel” field (Ctrl+V) — the field is multi-line, so you can paste the entire block at once.
5. Enter the same email address you used at purchase.
6. Click Activate. The script switches to the full version right away — no restart needed, and your categories and plugins stay in place.

The license is tied to a specific computer (Machine ID). If you change computers or reinstall your system, you don't need to buy it again — you move it yourself, as described below.

Moving your license to another computer

1. On the old computer, open Options → License section (the last one) and click “Deactivate license”. The script switches to demo mode.
2. On the new computer, launch Plugin Shelf, click “I have a key - activate” and copy the Machine ID from the activation screen.
3. Click “Open customer panel” (on the activation screen or in Options → License) free the old computer's seat there, then issue a key for the new Machine ID.
4. Activate the license on the new computer the same way as on first launch.

If the old computer no longer works or you don't have it anymore, skip step 1. The number of operations in the customer panel (freeing a seat, issuing a key) within a given period is limited; the limit renews by itself. The key of a freed computer stops working. If you want to go back to a computer whose seat you already freed and the panel won't issue a key for it, contact the seller.

Perpetual license and additional computers

The license is perpetual — you pay once, with no subscription and no recurring fees. One license works on one computer at a time. If you want to use Plugin Shelf on several computers at the same time (e.g. in the studio, on a laptop and at home), buy up to two additional seats under the same email address — they cost less (see the shop for the price). That's up to three computers at once; if you need more, contact the seller. Each seat has its own key, bound to that computer's Machine ID.

Email address visible in the window

After activation, a discreet “Licensed to: [your email]” label appears in the bottom-right corner of the main window. This is a deliberate safeguard — it discourages passing your copy along, since your email stays visible on any screenshot or recording. The label is very subtle and doesn't get in the way of normal work.



Online license verification (new in version 3.2)

Alongside the digital signature checked locally, the script also periodically connects to a server to confirm your license is still valid. This is an extra safeguard that allows the key to be revoked remotely — for example, after a refund or in case of fraud.

This check does NOT require a constant internet connection — if you happen to be offline, the script simply keeps working, with no time limit at all. The only thing that actually blocks access to the full version is an explicit confirmation from the server that the key has been revoked — simply lacking an internet connection never does that on its own. After a revocation, the script shows a message and switches to demo mode.
Tip: *Plugin Shelf comes with a separate script that replaces REAPER's native window — pressing the FX button on a track (TCP), in the mixer (MCP), or on plugin slots automatically opens Plugin Shelf instead of REAPER's native plugin browser.*

3. Main window — overview

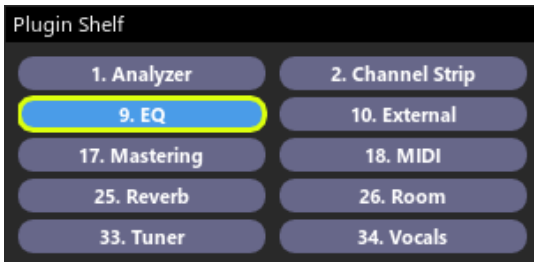
The Plugin Shelf main window is made up of a few fixed elements:

- Navigation bar with categories (top) — clicking switches the view; category names are bold for better readability
- Plugin tile grid (middle) — each tile is one plugin, with an icon and name; the tile under the mouse cursor grows slightly
- Search field
- Bottom icon bar — Search plugins, Add category, Add plugin, Create chain, All notes, Options; each icon's name appears when you hover over it (after about 1 s)
- The “View: categories / developers” (chapter 4b), “Global search” (chapter 7), “Auto-float FX” and “Close after insert” switches — icons in the bottom right corner
-



Active category

The category you're currently in gets an extra, clearly visible border on the navigation bar — not just a different background color. You can fine-tune the thickness, rounding and color of that border in Options.



Highlighting the found plugin's category

When you search on the Home page, or inside a category with “Global search” ON, hovering over a result highlights the category on the bar that the plugin actually lives in. The highlight has its own color — “Category of the found plugin (search)” in Options → Colors — different from the active category color, so you can see it even when the plugin is in the category you're in.

Windows and popups

Plugin Shelf's popups (Options, Search plugins, Add/Edit plugin, Add category, Notepad, Presets, Choose icon and others) are regular windows — they don't block the main window or each other. You can, for example, keep Options open and click tiles at the same time. Only short questions like “Delete for sure?” block.

The bottom bar icons work as toggles: while a window is open, its icon is highlighted, and clicking it again closes the window. You can move any window by its title bar or by any empty space.

By default the main window and the popups stay always on top, and popups open on the Plugin Shelf window's screen (the first time in its center, then wherever you left them). You can turn each of these off in Options → Window. Warnings, questions and the file picker always show above the script's windows.

Docking: drag the main window with **Shift** held down onto a spot in REAPER's docker. You take it out of the docker with a normal drag or right-click → Undock. A docked window is not “always on top”.

Where plugins go: track, master, item, Monitoring FX (new in version 3.7.94)

Clicking a tile inserts the plugin on the selected tracks — the master track counts as a track too, so select the master (alone or with other tracks) to put a plugin on it. Selected items get the plugin on their active take; when both tracks and items are selected, the last place you clicked in REAPER decides.

Monitoring FX (the chain after the master, used only for listening): open REAPER's “FX: Monitoring” window (View → Monitoring FX) and click a tile — while that window is open and was the last FX window you clicked, plugins go there. Any time, regardless of the selection: right-click a tile → “Insert into Monitoring FX”.

Each click adds another instance of the plugin at the end of the chain, also when the same plugin is already there.

Close after insert (new in version 3.7.94)

The window-with-a-cross icon next to “Auto-float FX” closes the Plugin Shelf window right after you insert a plugin or a chain (from a tile, with a preset, into Monitoring FX or from “Create chain”). Green = on. Open Plugin Shelf again with your shortcut or toolbar button. The setting is remembered.

Messages and questions (e.g. “Select a track or item first”), and windows that a plugin opens while it is being inserted (activation, registration), always show up above the Plugin Shelf window, even when it is set to stay on top.

4. Categories

Categories are your own way of organizing plugins — you set the names, order, and colors yourself.

Creating a category

Click the “Add category” icon on the bottom bar (or right-click an empty spot on the category bar), type a name, and confirm.



Changing the order

Right-click a category on the navigation bar → “Move to position” and pick the new spot.

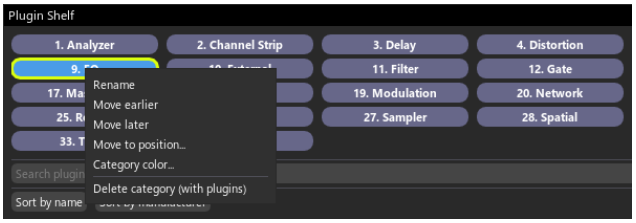
Category color

Right-click a category → pick a color from the palette. The color helps you visually tell categories apart on the navigation bar. The same window sets the category's text color. You can also pick both colors right when you create a category (“Set category color” in Add category, Add plugin and Edit properties).



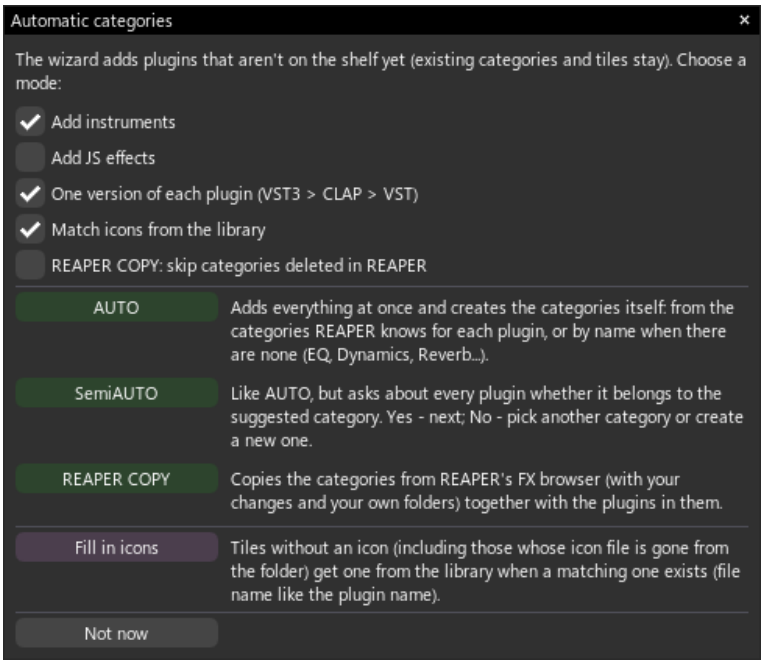
Sorting a category's contents

Inside an open category (not on the home page) you'll find “Sort by name” and “Sort by manufacturer” buttons — one click arranges every tile in that category. This isn't a temporary view sort — the new order is saved permanently, exactly as if you'd repositioned every tile by hand.



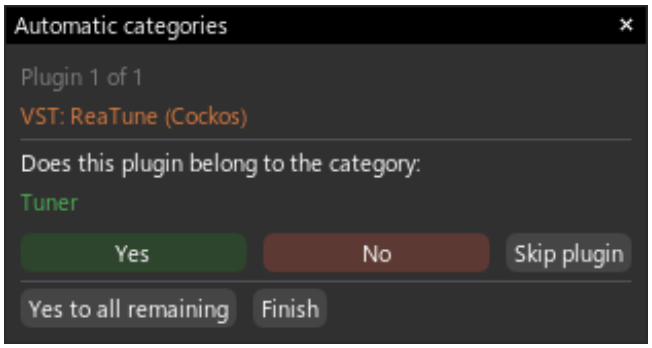
4b. Automatic categories (new in version 3.3)

You don't have to add plugins one by one. When the shelf is empty (e.g. on first launch), the home page shows a welcome screen with the logo and an “Automatic categories...” button — click it, and the wizard adds your installed plugins and sorts them into categories. Later you'll find it in Options → Maintenance (“Automatic categories...”). The wizard only adds plugins that aren't on the shelf yet — existing categories and tiles stay unchanged.



Three modes

- AUTO — adds everything at once and creates the categories itself: from the categories REAPER knows for each plugin (the same ones as in REAPER's FX browser), or by name when there are none. Instruments go to “Instrument”, and plugins that can't be assigned go to “Other”.
- SemiAUTO — like AUTO, but asks about every plugin: “Does this plugin belong to the category…?”. Yes — the plugin is added and the wizard moves on. No — pick another category from the list or type a name for a new one. You can also skip a plugin, click “Yes to all remaining” (the rest goes as in AUTO) or finish.



- REAPER COPY — copies the categories from REAPER's FX browser together with the plugins in them, including your category changes and your own folders (a folder becomes a category). A plugin with

several categories in REAPER shows up in each of them (the first is its main category, the rest are tags), and plugins with no category go to “No category” — just like in REAPER's FX browser.

Category names are the same as in REAPER (EQ, Dynamics, Reverb, Delay…). You can rename, color and arrange them later like any other category (chapter 4). Adding runs with a progress bar and you can stop it at any time.

Wizard options

- Add instruments — on by default.
- Add JS effects — off by default, as REAPER ships hundreds of them.
- One version of each plugin — when a plugin is installed in several formats, only one is added (order: VST3, CLAP, VST).
- Match icons from the library — tiles get matching icons right away (chapter 5, “Choosing an icon”).
- REAPER COPY: skip categories deleted in REAPER — off by default.

Fill in icons

The “Fill in icons” button in the wizard assigns library icons to tiles that don't have one yet or whose icon file is gone from the folder (e.g. after file names changed in a new icon pack) — handy e.g. after adding new icons to the script folder. Tiles that already have an icon stay as they are.

Icon matching knows other spellings of the same developer and other versions of the same plugin (new in version 3.7.94): e.g. “kHs Compressor” gets the “Kilohearts Compressor” icon, Acqua / “…ZL” plugins get the Acustica icons, “iZotope, Inc.” = iZotope, Cockos = Reaper, and RX 11 gets the RX10 icon. Run “Fill in icons” again to give icons to tiles that did not get one before.

Developer view

The “View: categories / developers” button in the bottom right corner, next to “Auto-float FX”, switches the navigation bar between your categories and the plugin developers — read from the plugin names, just like the developer filter in the scan window. In the developer view, click a tile to insert the plugin; editing, sorting and the right-click menu work in the category view. The chosen view is remembered.

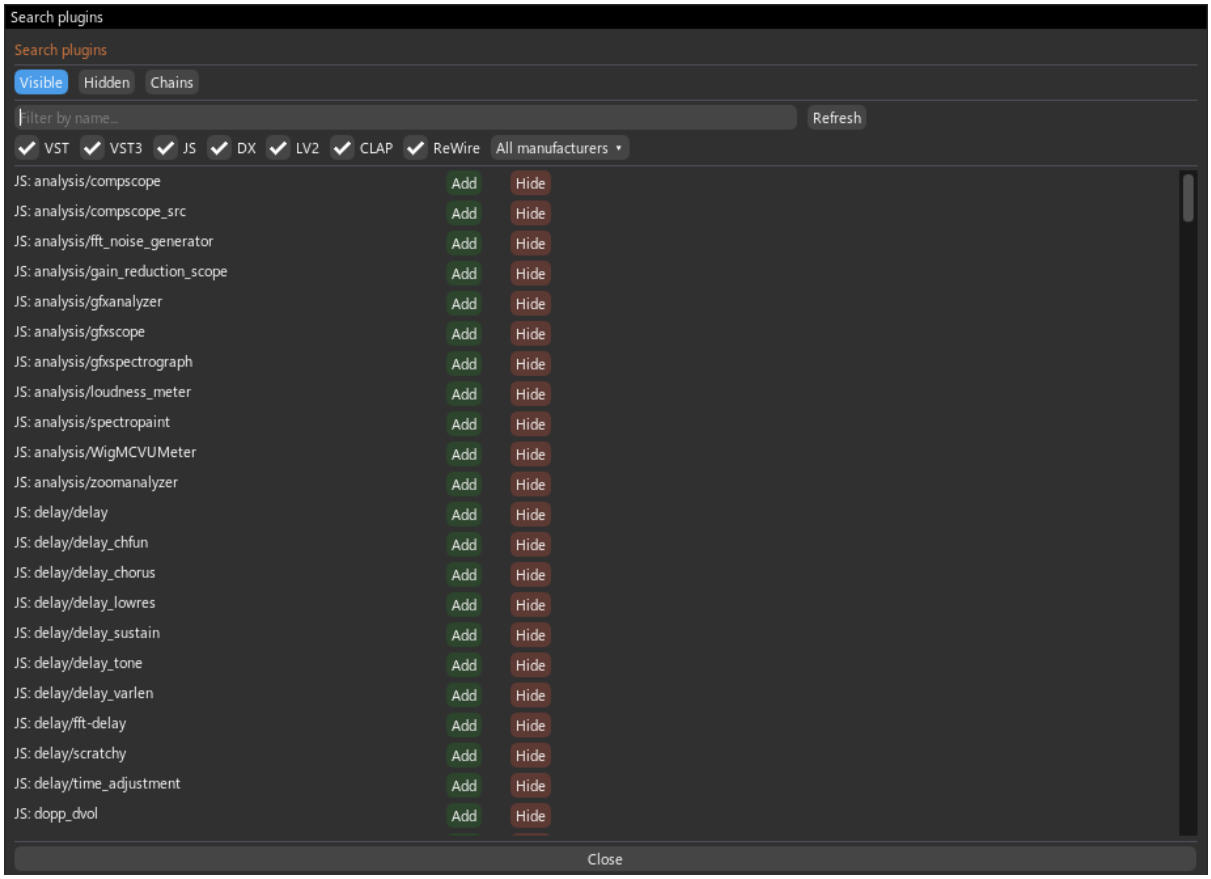


In the demo version the wizard works within the limits (chapter 16) and shows at the end how many plugins didn't fit.

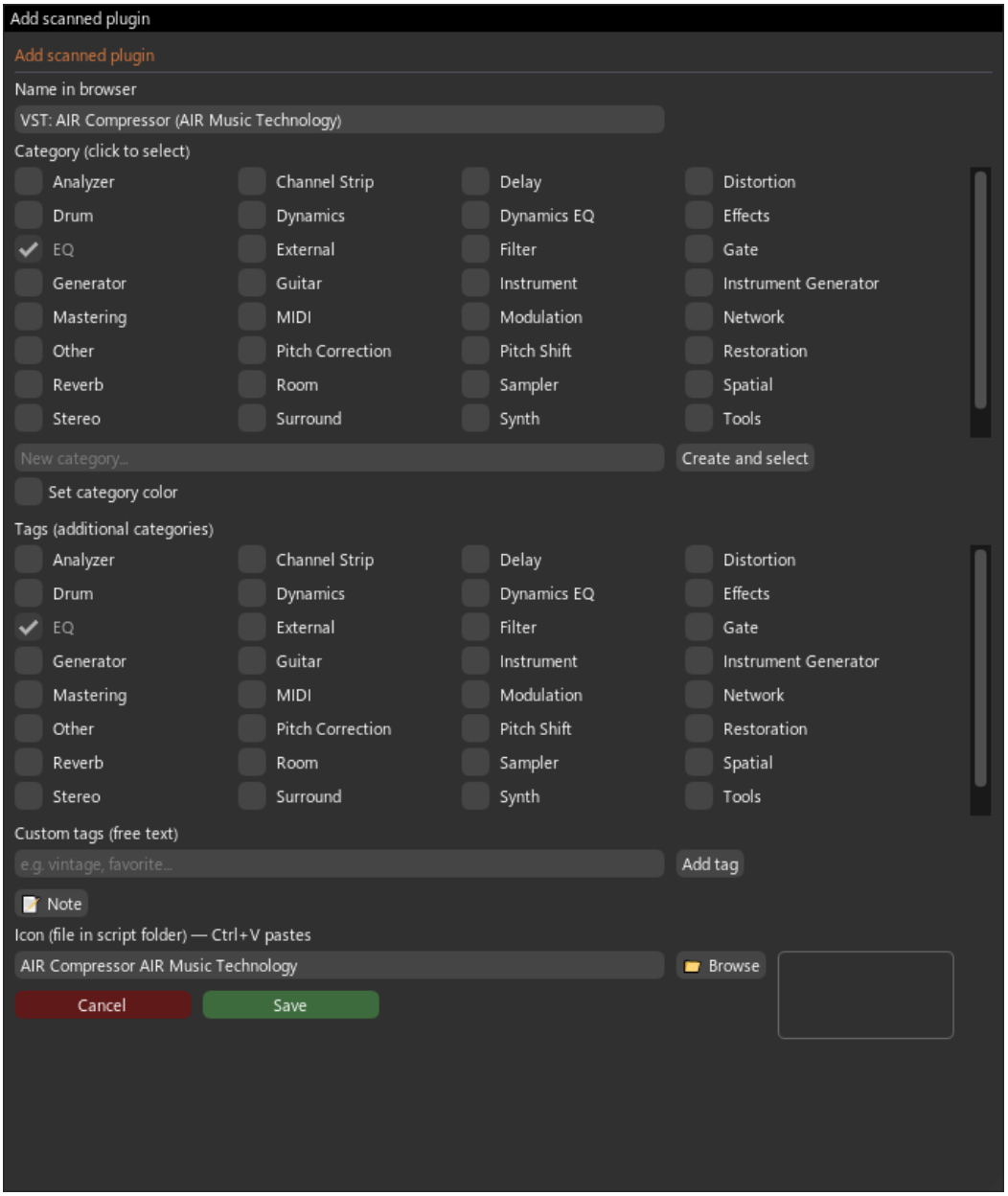
5. Adding plugins

Via the scanner (recommended)

1. Click the “Search plugins” icon on the bottom bar (or right-click an empty spot in the tile area → “Search plugins”).
2. You'll see a list of all installed plugins that haven't been added yet.
3. You can filter by name or manufacturer.
4. Click "Add" next to the plugin you want.



5. In the window that opens, give it a name, pick the target category, and add tags, notes, and an icon



Choosing an icon

The script ships with a library of over 4000 plugin icons, which is regularly updated with new additions.

When adding a plugin, the script suggests a matching icon based on its name — but you still need to confirm it from the suggestion list, or pick your own via “Browse”.



Making your own icons

Nothing stops you from creating your own icons instead of relying only on the bundled library — the ones shipped with the script are made in Canva. A single icon's format is 120×60 px.

If you want the script to assign your icon automatically (when adding, in the automatic categories wizard and with “Fill in icons”), name the file the way REAPER shows the plugin: “EmelowskyFX - ”, then the developer and the plugin name. Example: for the plugin “VST3: UADx 1176 Rev A Compressor (Universal Audio (UADx))”, a good file name would be:
EmelowskyFX - UADx 1176 Rev A Compressor.png

Letter case, spaces and hyphens don't matter, and Mono/Stereo suffixes can be left out — one icon “EmelowskyFX - Chaos Audio Apollo.png” matches both “Apollo Mono” and “Apollo Stereo”. You can still add an icon under a completely different name and pick it manually via “Browse”.

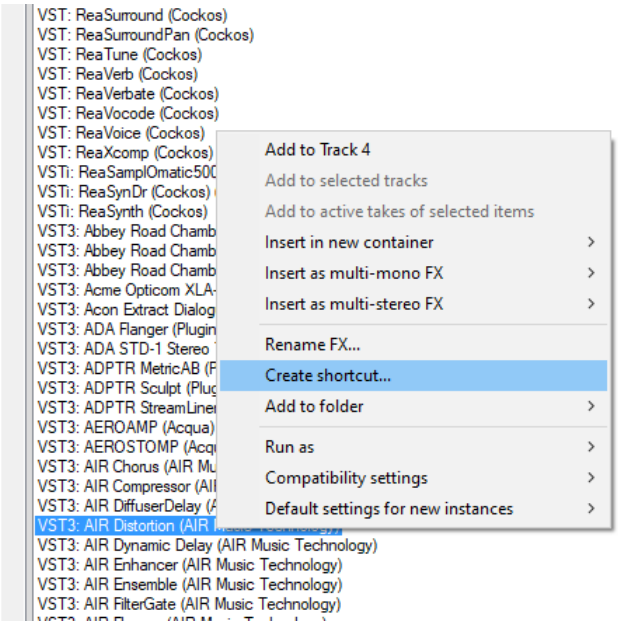
Adding manually and any action

If a plugin isn't in the scanner (rare cases), or you want a tile to run another REAPER action, add it manually: click the “Add plugin” icon on the bottom bar (or right-click an empty spot in the tile area → “Add plugin”).

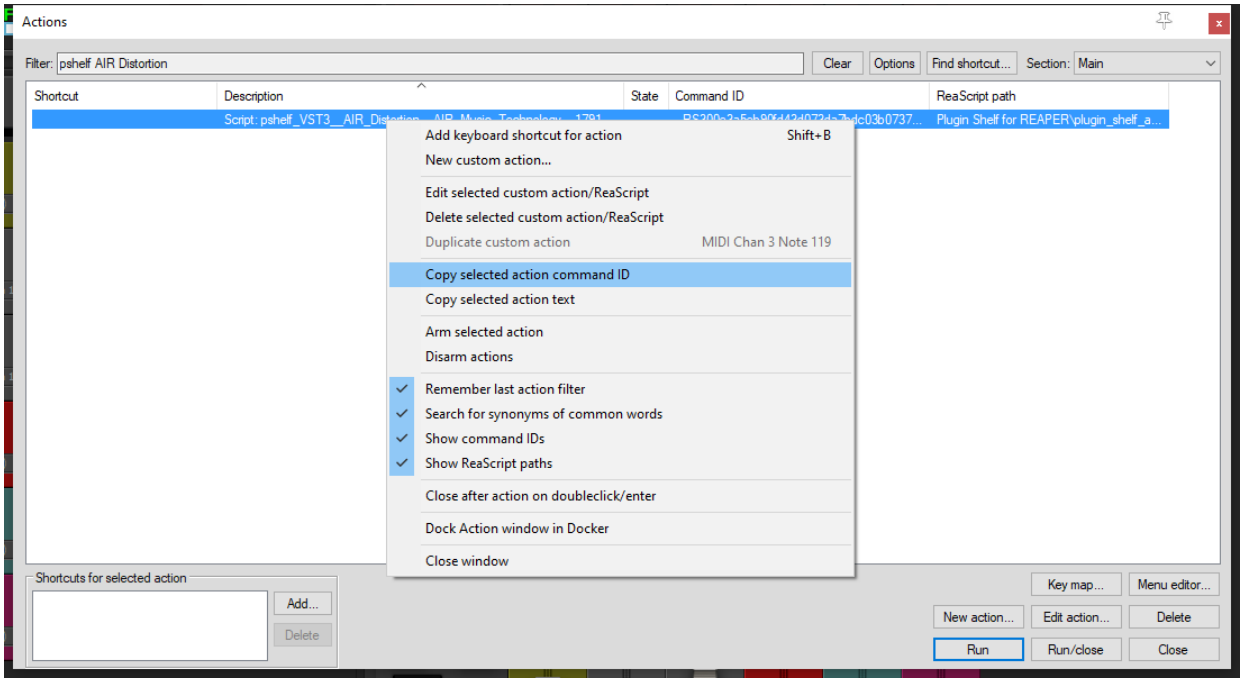
The easiest way is to click **“Browse...”** next to the action field. A list of REAPER actions whose description starts with “Insert FX:” opens — type part of the name into the filter and click an entry. The script fills in the tile name (without the “Insert FX:” prefix) and the action. Fill in the category, tags, notes and icon, and save.

If your plugin isn't on that list, first create an action for it in REAPER:

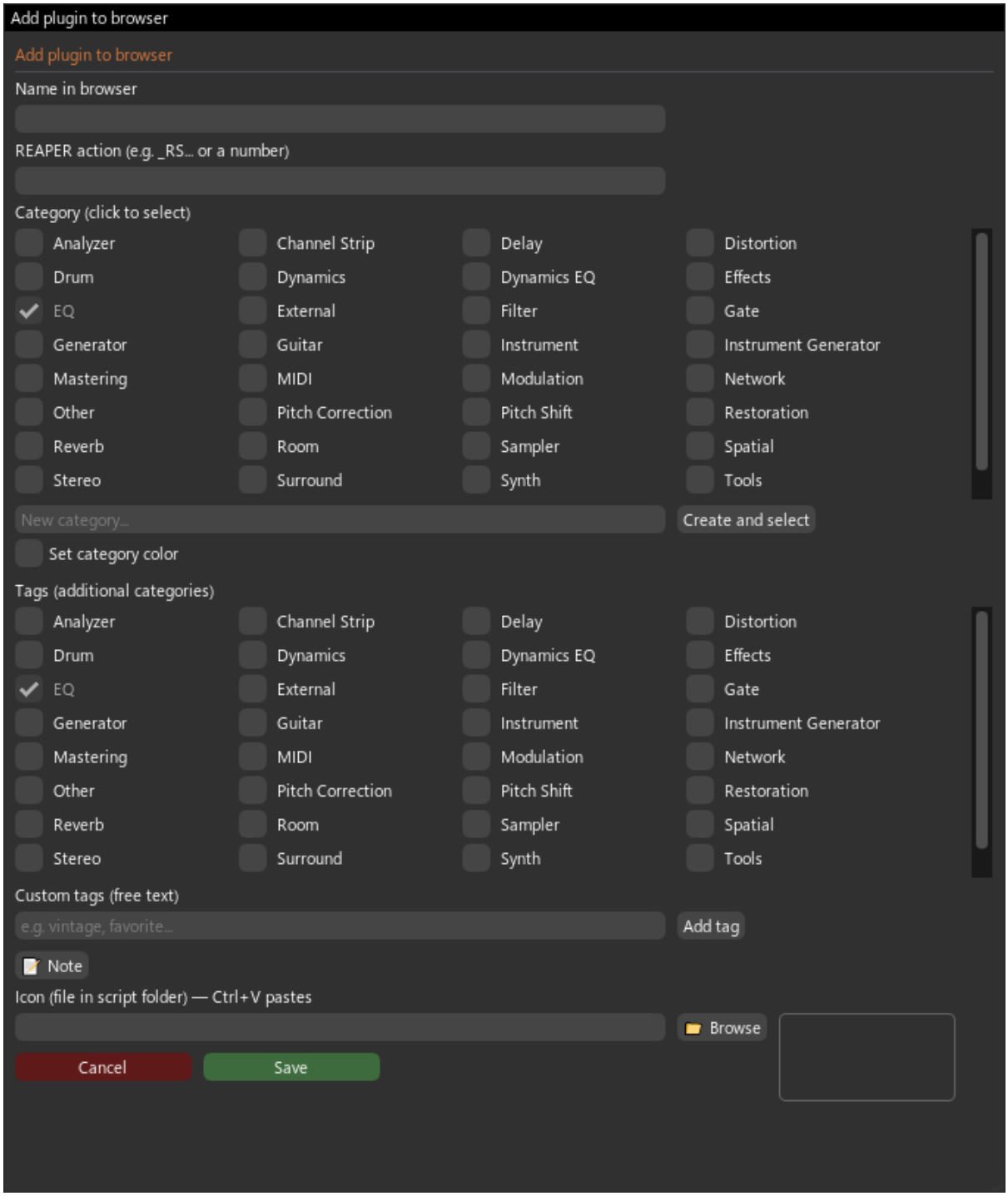
Open REAPER's native FX browser, right-click the plugin and choose “Create shortcut…”. A shortcuts window opens — close it. A new “Insert FX: …” action now appears in the Action List.



Go back to “Browse...” — the new action is on the list now. You can also copy its Command ID from the Action List and paste it into the action field by hand.



The action field accepts **any** REAPER action (Command ID, e.g. _RS… or a number) — a tile doesn't have to insert a plugin. That way you can build, for example, a “Macros” category with tiles that run your favorite actions and scripts.


Add plugin to browser
Add plugin to browser
Name in browser
REAPER action (e.g. _RS... or a number)
Category (click to select)
Analyzer
Channel Strip
Delay
Distortion
Drum
Dynamics
Dynamics EQ
Effects
EQ
External
Filter
Gate
Generator
Guitar
Instrument
Instrument Generator
Mastering
MIDI
Modulation
Network
Other
Pitch Correction
Pitch Shift
Restoration
Reverb
Room
Sampler
Spatial
Stereo
Surround
Synth
Tools
New category...
Create and select
Set category color
Tags (additional categories)
Analyzer
Channel Strip
Delay
Distortion
Drum
Dynamics
Dynamics EQ
Effects
EQ
External
Filter
Gate
Generator
Guitar
Instrument
Instrument Generator
Mastering
MIDI
Modulation
Network
Other
Pitch Correction
Pitch Shift
Restoration
Reverb
Room
Sampler
Spatial
Stereo
Surround
Synth
Tools
Custom tags (free text)
e.g. vintage, favorite...
Add tag
Note
Icon (file in script folder) — Ctrl+V pastes
Browse
Cancel
Save

Icon from a screen capture (new in version 3.3)

The quickest way to get your own icon: capture it straight from the screen — for example from the open plugin window.

1. Open the plugin window (or anything else you want as the icon) so that it's visible on screen.
2. Right-click the plugin's tile and choose “Add icon from screen capture”. The “(in 3 s)” variant gives you 3 seconds to bring the plugin window to the front.
3. The screen “freezes” — drag a rectangle around the part you want. The selection always keeps a 2:1 ratio, the same as a tile.
4. Drag the middle of the selection to move it, or one of its corners to resize it — the opposite corner stays in place and the 2:1 ratio is kept. Esc clears the selection so you can draw a new one; a right-click closes the tool without saving.
5. Press Enter — the icon appears on the tile right away.

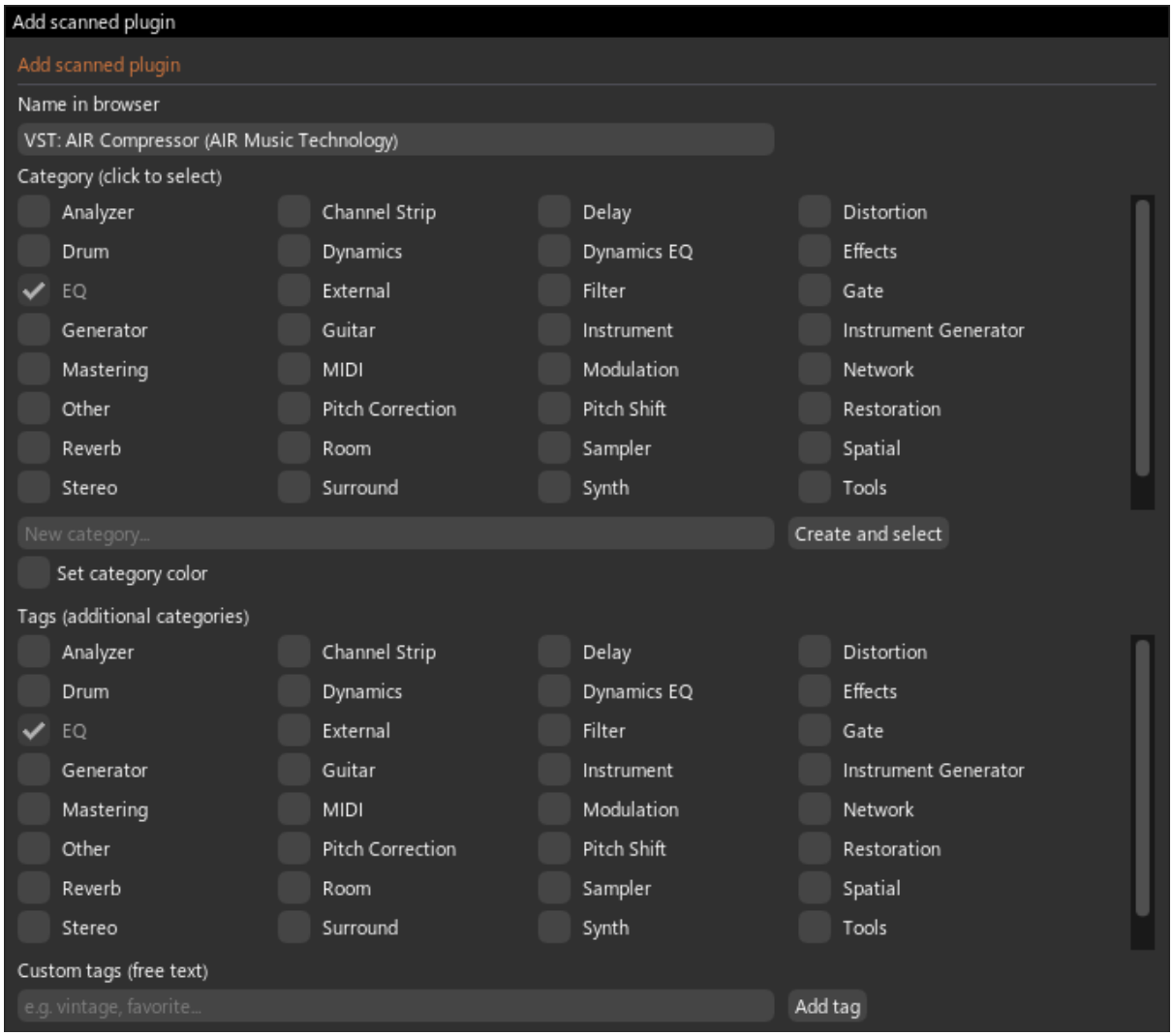


The icon is saved in the script folder as “EmelowskyFX - <plugin name> (custom).png” (240×120 px), so the bundled icons are never overwritten. This feature needs the free js_ReaScriptAPI extension (installed via ReaPack, just like ReaImGui) — without it, the rest of Plugin Shelf works normally.

6. Tags

Tags let one plugin show up in more than one category — without duplicating it. A plugin has its “home category” (where it actually belongs), and tags additionally add it to other views.

Useful, for example, when you have an EQ that you want to see in both the “Instruments” and “MultiFX” categories.



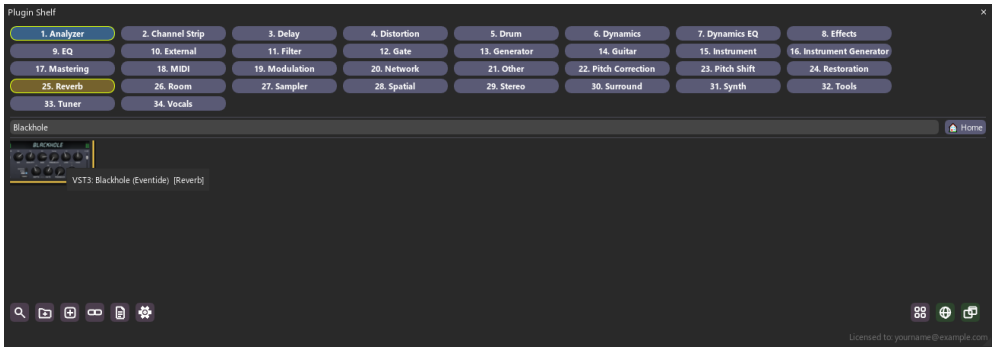
7. Search and “Most used”

Search

On the Home page, the search field at the top of the main window searches all categories at once. You can type several word fragments in any order — for example, typing “comp wa” will find “Waves Compressor”, even though the words are in reverse order.



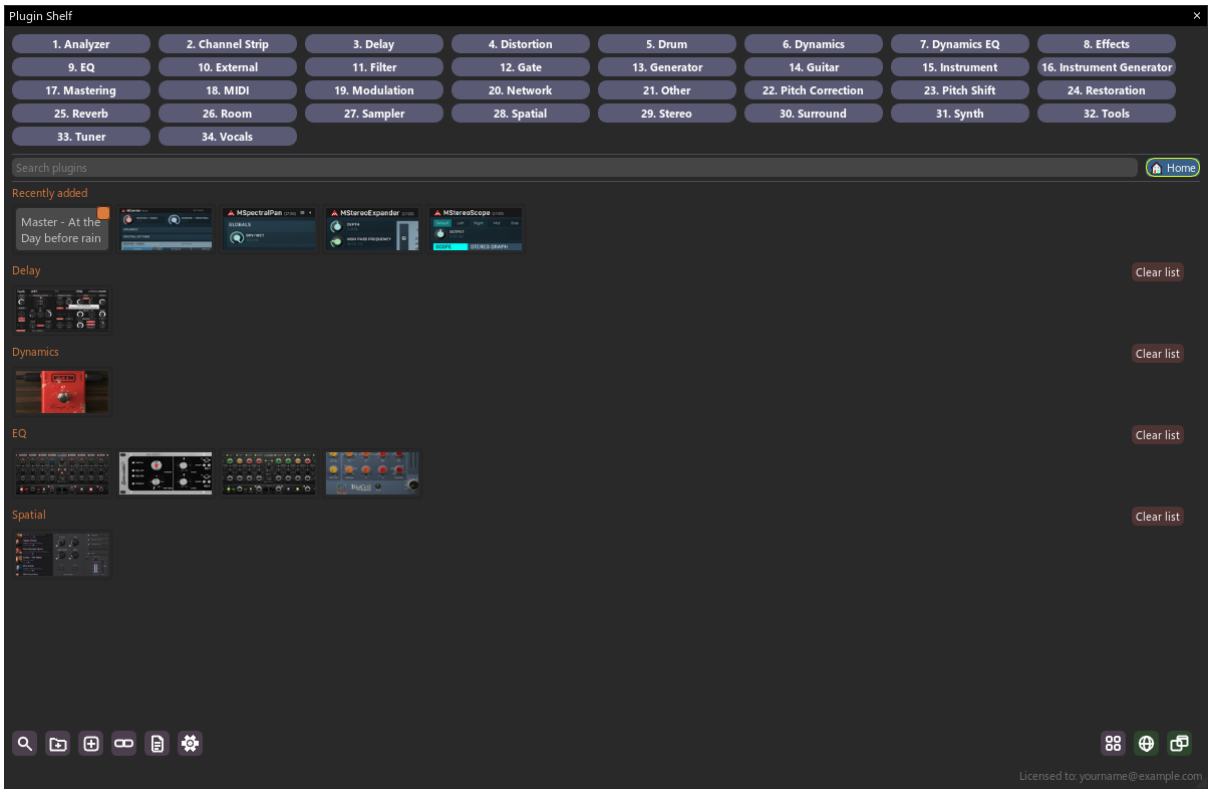
Inside an open category (for example EQ), the “Global search” switch in the bottom right corner, next to “Auto-float FX”, decides what gets searched. “Global search OFF” (red, the default) — the search box filters only the current category. “Global search ON” (green) — it searches all categories, just like on the Home page; the sort buttons are hidden then, because the results come from many categories. The setting is remembered.



Hovering over a result highlights its category on the bar — see chapter 3, “Highlighting the found plugin's category”.

Most used

On the home page you'll see a section with the plugins you use most — the script keeps track of how many times you've inserted each one. You set the number of items in this section (“TOP per category”) in Options.

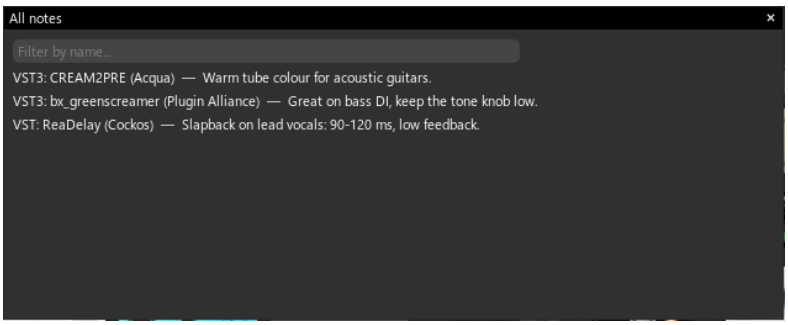


The example shows my own plugin library and Options settings.

8. Notes, hiding, undoing deletion

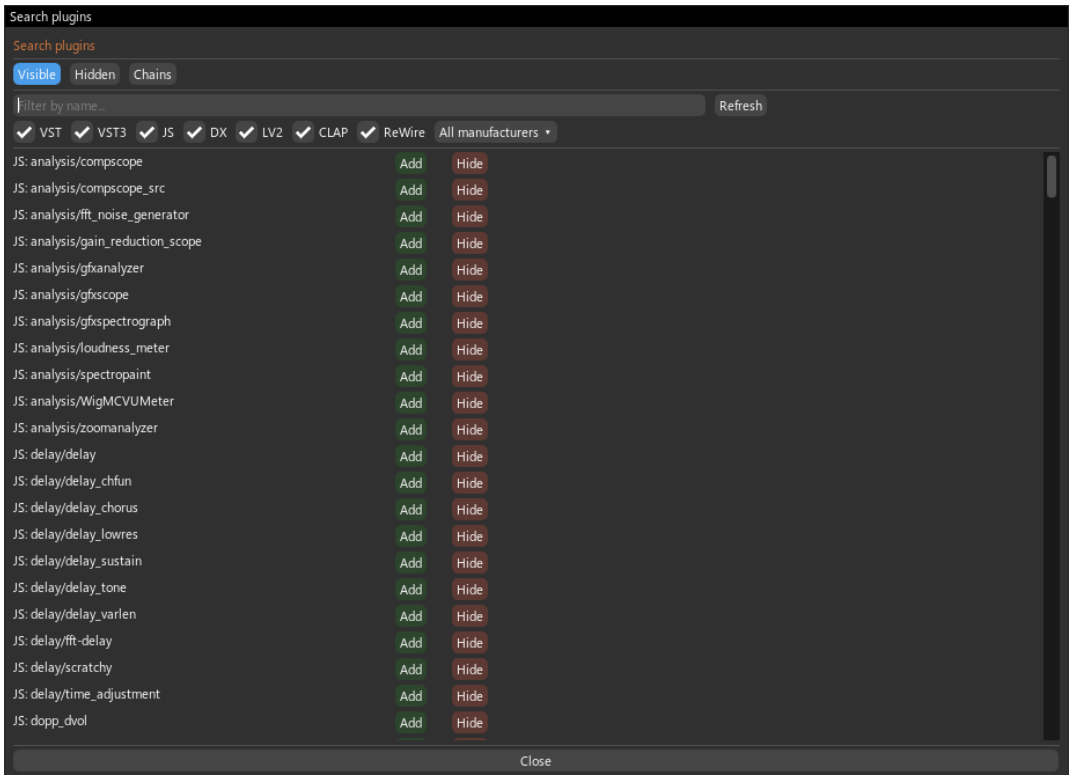
Notes

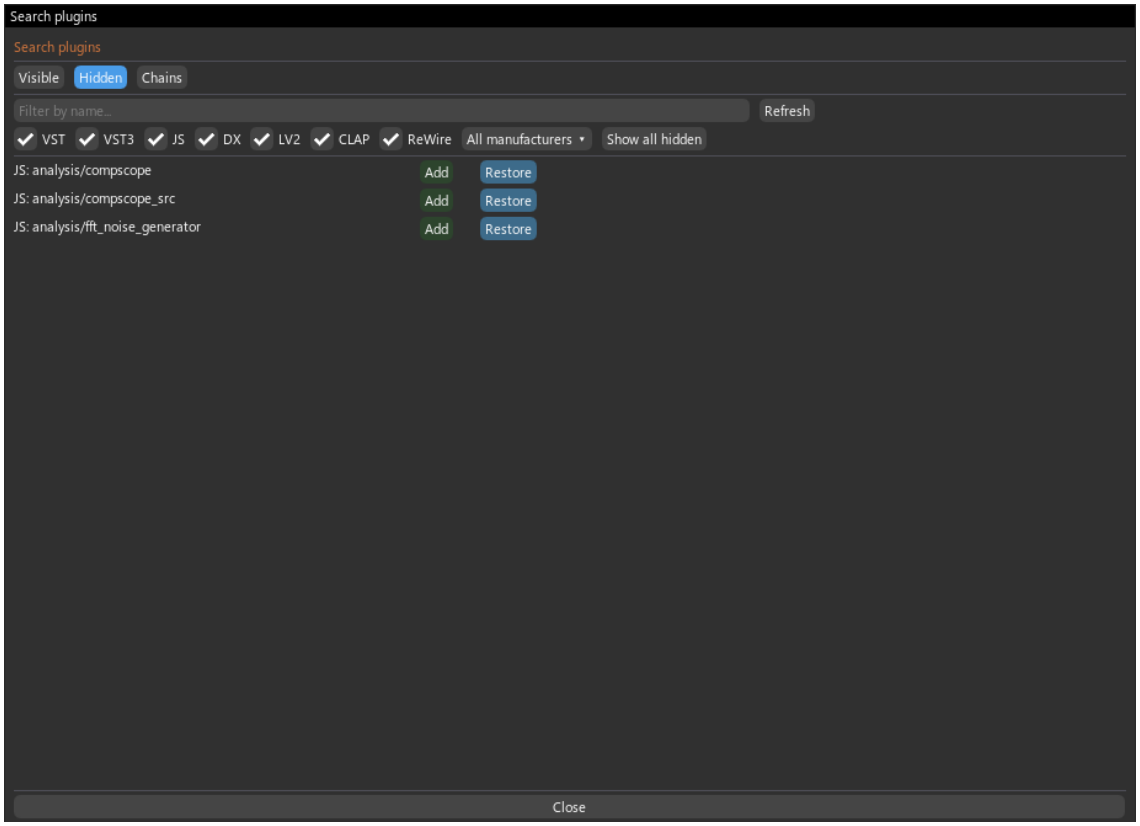
You can add your own note to each plugin (e.g. what you use it for, which settings you like). You can see all notes at once in the “All notes” view from the bottom bar. Clicking an entry inserts the plugin (just like clicking its tile); right-click opens the plugin and its note for editing.



Hiding plugins

Instead of deleting a plugin, you can hide it (the “Hidden” tab in the scanner panel). A hidden plugin doesn't clutter the view but stays in your data, and you can restore it any time with the “Restore” button, or unhide everything at once with “Show all hidden”.





Undoing a deletion and deletion history

If you delete a plugin or category by mistake, the "Undo" button restores the latest deletion — the plugin goes back to its category, in the same spot. Further clicks on "Undo" restore earlier deletions (newest first).

*The **"History"** button next to it opens the "Deletion history" window with the last 20 deletions (newest at the top). Tick one or more entries and click "Restore selected" — each plugin returns to its category, in its original spot. Deleting several selected tiles at once is one entry and is restored as a whole. The history is kept after you close the script.*

Quick delete (new in version 3.7.94)

Right-click a tile, then press Delete or Backspace — it works like “Delete plugin” in that menu (same question, and the deletion goes to the deletion history, so you can undo it).

9. Bulk actions

Hold Ctrl and click tiles to select several plugins at once. Selected tiles will show a bar with the available bulk actions:

- Move to category — moves everything selected at once
- Delete selected — deletes everything selected at once (one entry in the deletion history — “Undo” restores them all)
- Move to position — moves the whole selected group at once, keeping their relative order
- Clear selection

You can also drag tiles with the mouse — one at a time or several selected ones together: onto a category on the top bar = move into it; to another spot in the same category = reorder (the selected group moves together and keeps its order, and the other tiles make room).

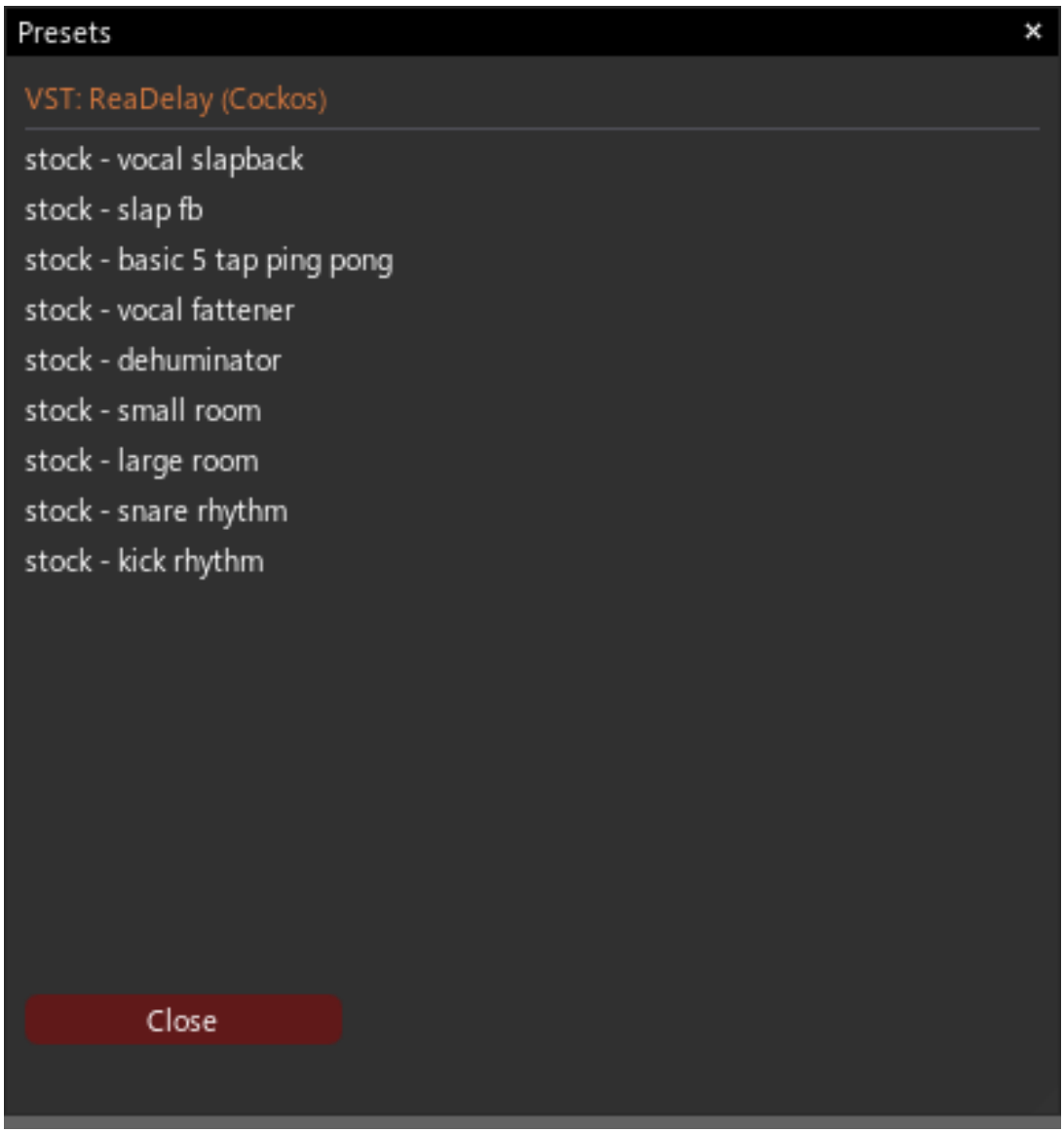


10. Factory presets

Right-click a plugin tile — if the plugin's manufacturer provided factory presets visible in REAPER's native window, a separate small window opens with their list (deliberately a separate window, not a dropdown submenu — with some heavier plugins, the submenu could unexpectedly close mid-way).

These aren't presets from inside the plugin itself, the way UAD does it, for example — they come from REAPER's native window, the way Plugin Alliance does it, for example. That means if they're not there, or you haven't created any yourself, Plugin Shelf will report that no presets are available.

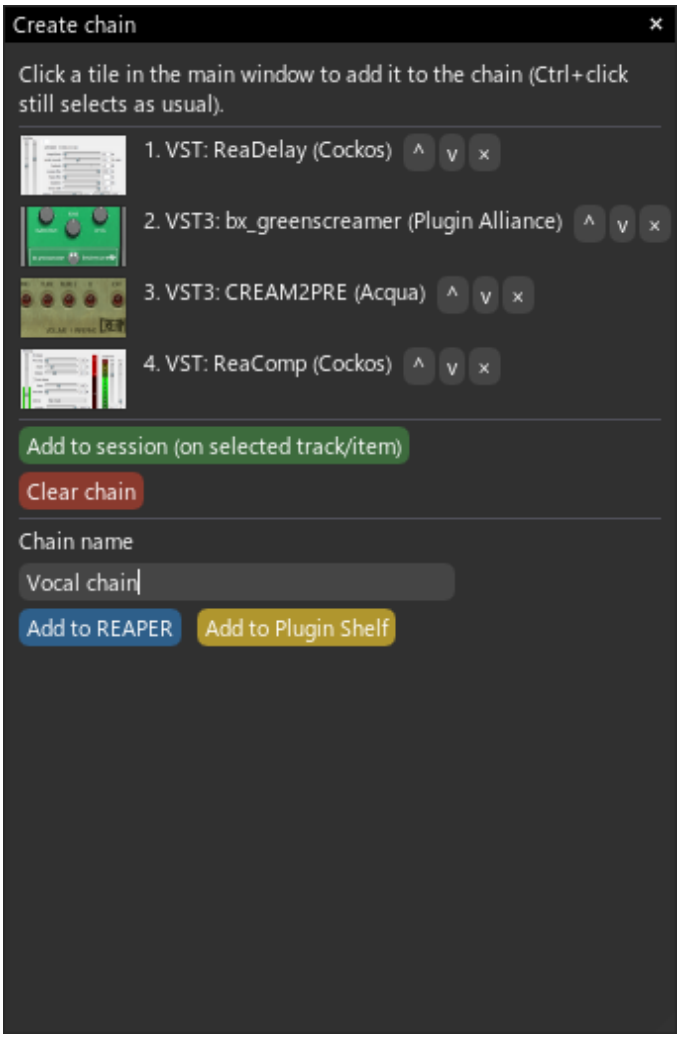
Selecting a preset from the list inserts the plugin with that preset already applied.



11. FX chains

Building a chain

1. Click “Create chain” on the bottom bar — a separate window opens.
2. Click tiles in the main window to add plugins to the chain one by one. You can add a plugin with a preset (see *“10. Factory presets”*)
3. In the “Create chain” window you see a live preview of the list being built — you can reorder and remove items.
4. Give the chain a name.
5. Save it as a REAPER chain file (if a default category is set in Options, it'll land there) or insert it directly onto the selected track/item.

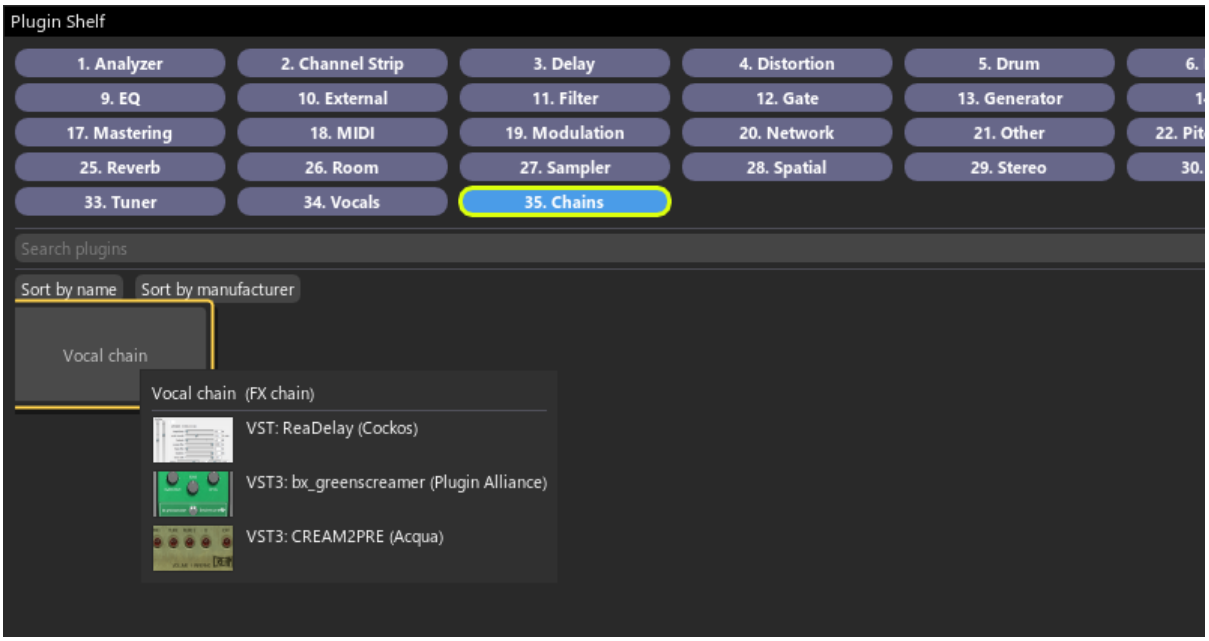


Add to session (onto the selected track/item) – adds the chain directly onto the track(s) or item(s) as-is, without saving it for later.

Add to REAPER – Saves the chain in the C:\Users\ \AppData\Roaming\REAPER\FXChains folder, i.e. where REAPER sees chains by default

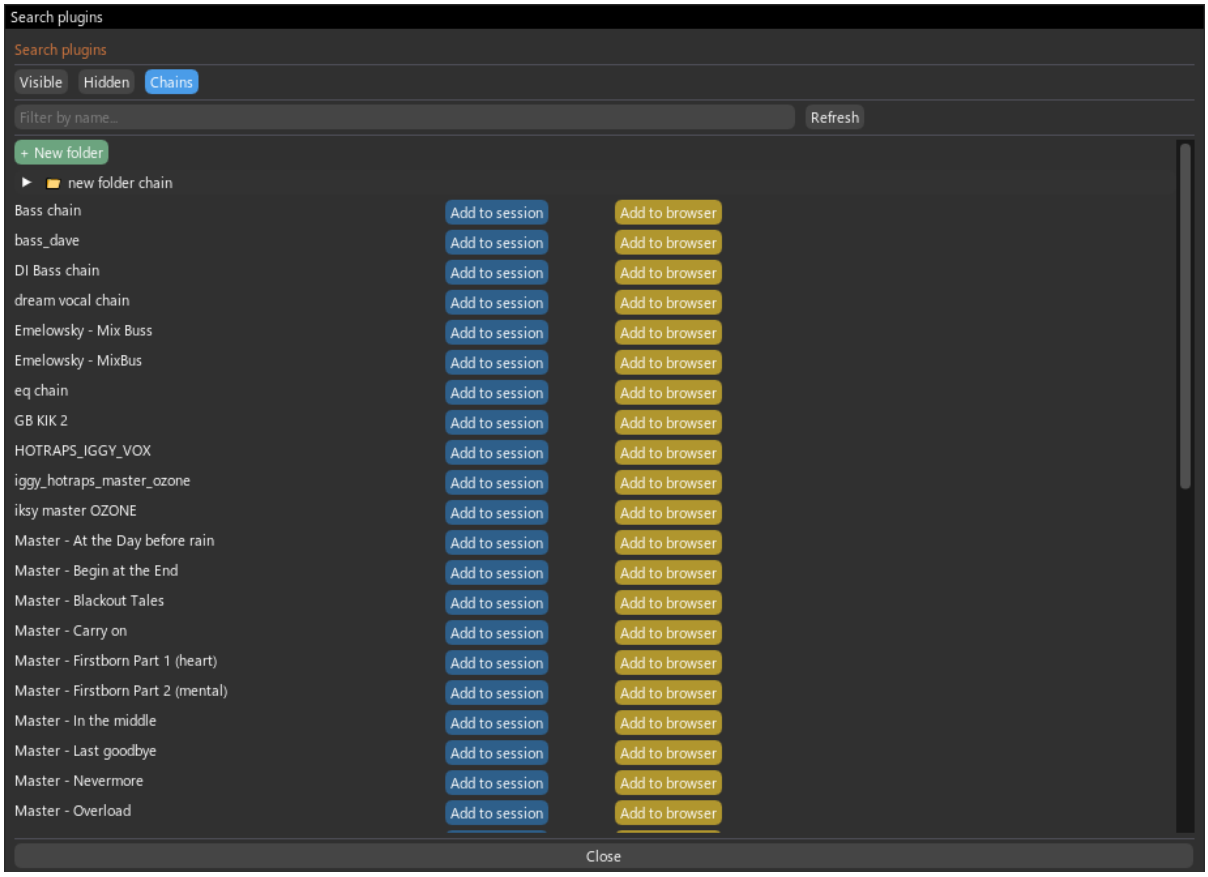
Add to Plugin Shelf – does exactly what Add to REAPER does, with the difference that it also creates a tile in Plugin Shelf, letting you add tags, notes, and an icon.

Hovering over a chain tile shows which plugins are in the chain — the script reads them from the chain file (.RfxChain). If the plugins had presets selected when the chain was built, those are shown too.



Managing chain folders

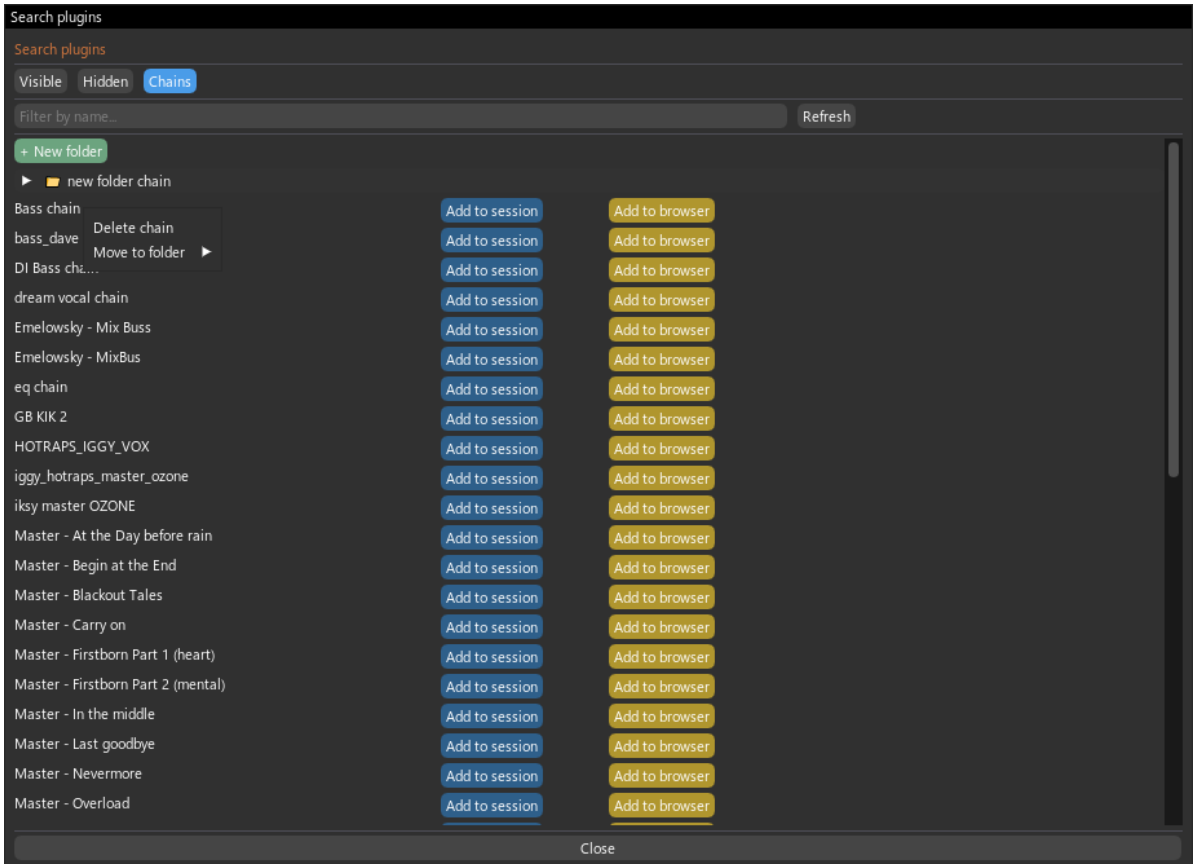
In the “Chains” tab (Search plugins panel) you can organize your saved chains into folders — create new ones, rename, move, copy, and delete them, without leaving REAPER.



Selecting multiple chains at once

Just like with plugin tiles, in the Chains tab you can hold Ctrl and click chains to select several at once — selected rows get a clear, colored background. A bar with bulk actions then appears:

- Move selected to folder — moves all selected chains at once into the chosen folder
- Delete selected chains — deletes everything selected at once (with confirmation, cannot be undone)
- Clear selection
-



Adding a chain to REAPER (Add to session / Add to browser) only works one at a time, for a single chain — these are the only actions that can't be done in bulk.

Hovering over a chain in this list shows a tooltip with its effects. A chain added from here with "Add to browser" also gets thumbnails of the plugins it contains — even if it wasn't made in Plugin Shelf, because the script reads them from the chain file. If the file can't be read, there are simply no thumbnails.

If the same chain is already in the browser

The script recognizes the same chain file no matter what name you try to add it under again — if you try to add an already-added chain under a different name, you'll see a message telling you what name and category it's already under, e.g.: "'Dream Vocal' already exists in the browser under the name 'Super Vocal' (in category 'Vocal')". This means you don't have to remember what you called a chain before.

12. Quick Switch

Quick Switch is the fastest way to switch categories without touching the mouse.

How to use it (default settings)

1. Press Left Alt.
2. A small window with category numbers appears in the middle of the window.
3. Type the category number (two digits switch immediately; one digit + Enter also works).
4. “0” or “00” goes back to the home page.
5. Esc, or a few seconds of inactivity, closes the window without changing anything.



Changing the shortcut

In Options you can change the modifier (Ctrl / Left Alt / Right Alt / Shift) and the extra key that triggers Quick Switch, if the default clashes with something else in your workflow.

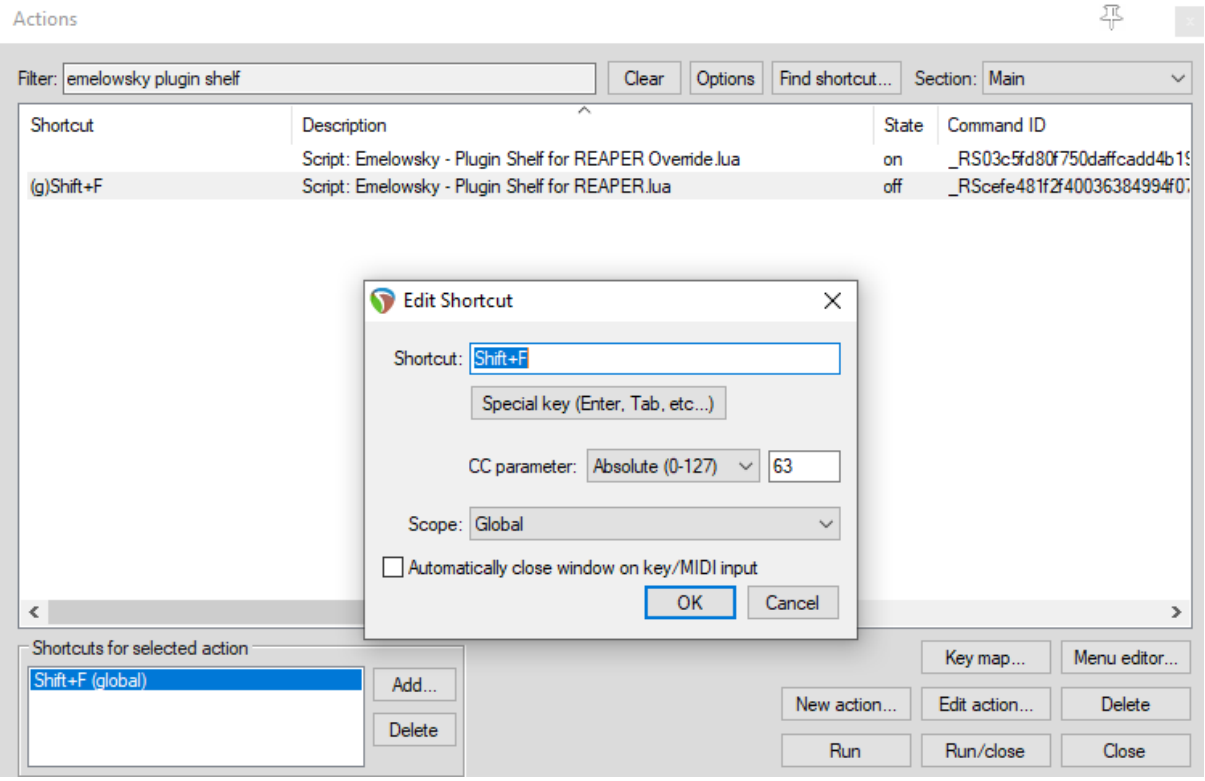
By default the shortcut is Left Alt alone, with no extra key (up to version 3.6 it was Ctrl + Space — it clashed with a REAPER shortcut, so the update switches it to Left Alt once; after that your choice applies). On macOS the script uses Mac key names: Cmd instead of Ctrl and Option instead of Alt.

13. Window ON/OFF shortcut

Plugin Shelf can be assigned to a single keyboard shortcut that toggles the window open and closed (exactly like REAPER's own native windows, e.g. the mixer).

How to set it up

1. Actions → Show action list, find Plugin Shelf in the list.
2. Right-click → Add shortcut... (or the F key, if that's how you have it set up).
3. Press the key combination you want.
4. IMPORTANT: in the shortcut assignment window, in the Scope field, choose “Global + text fields”, not just “Global”.



<u>If you set just “Global”, the shortcut will stop working whenever the Plugin Shelf window has focus (e.g. when you click into the search field) — you'd have to click somewhere in REAPER first for the shortcut to work again. Setting “Global + text fields” eliminates this problem entirely.</u>

TIP

Plugin Shelf comes with a separate script that replaces REAPER's native window — pressing the FX button on a track (TCP), in the mixer (MCP), or on plugin slots automatically opens Plugin Shelf instead of REAPER's native plugin browser. The process is fully reversible; simply deactivate the script, and the native plugin browser will open again. Details: the separate “Plugin Shelf for REAPER Override - Manual (EN)”.

14. Options panel — visual customization

Click the “Options” icon (gear) on the bottom bar to open the settings panel. Changes apply right away; close Options with the “Close” button at the bottom or with Esc.



What you can set

- Interface language (Polish / English / Spanish / German / French)
- The number of plugins in the “Most used” section (TOP per category)
- Tile size, spacing, and border thickness
- Hover zoom — how much the tile under the mouse cursor grows, in % of its size (default 20%, e.g. 100×50 → 120×60; 0 = off)
- The number of lines a name can wrap onto on a tile without its own icon
- Interface and font scale
- Font family and size
- Corner rounding — separately for buttons, the category bar, and tiles
- The thickness, rounding, and color of the ACTIVE category's border on the navigation bar, plus a separate color for highlighting the found plugin's category (chapter 3)
- Colors — separately for every significant interface element, via the color palette, including a separate background color for the main window and a separate one for popup windows
- Window: always on top — separately for the main window and for popups — and “Popups always on the script's screen” (all three on by default)
- The maximum number of category rows on the navigation bar
- The periodic backup interval (30 minutes by default)
- The Quick Switch modifier and key

- “About” — version, license status, seller e-mail, purchase page, customer panel and “Copy diagnostic info” (for support requests)
- Your license — deactivation on this computer and a link to the customer panel (License section, the last one)



In the colors section you'll also find a separate color for almost every single button in every panel (grouped by window: Common, License activation, Search plugins, Options, Category color, Add/Edit plugin, Create chain, Main window; sub-sections are indented like a folder tree) — if you care about a fully consistent, custom color scheme across the whole interface, this is where you can fine-tune it down to the very last button.

Restoring the default look

The “Restore defaults” button reverts ONLY the look (colors, font, rounding) to factory settings — your categories and plugins remain untouched.

14b. Maintenance

In the Options panel, in the Maintenance section, you'll find the “Refresh actions” tool.



Every plugin you add gets its own, separate action in REAPER's Action List — that's what lets you assign it a keyboard shortcut. “Refresh actions” performs a FULL cleanup: it removes ALL automatically generated action files from the script's folder (including orphaned ones, e.g. left over from moving a plugin to another category in earlier versions) and unregisters them from REAPER, then recreates fresh actions for every plugin currently in the browser.

Use this tool if you notice duplicated or inactive plugin actions in REAPER, or just periodically, to tidy up. Note: if you manually assigned a keyboard shortcut to a specific plugin in REAPER, you'll need to reassign it after refreshing — every refresh gives plugins new, internal action identifiers.

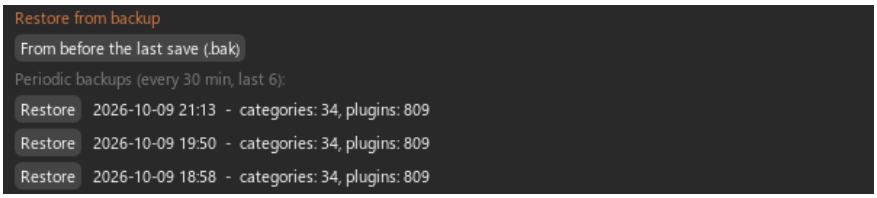
The same section has two more buttons:

- “Automatic categories…” — opens the wizard from chapter 4b.
- “Delete all categories and plugins” — after confirmation, clears the shelf. Your license, appearance and settings stay, the plugin actions are removed from REAPER's action list, and before clearing the script backs up your data as “user_plugins_3.x.lua.przed-czyszczeniem.bak”.

15. Backups, exporting and importing settings

Automatic backups

Plugin Shelf automatically backs up your data on every save (the state before the save), plus **periodic backups**: every 30 minutes (you can change the interval in Options) it writes a file with the date and time, keeping the last 6 — about 3 hours back. A periodic backup stores the state before the change, and closing and reopening the script doesn't overwrite it.



Restoring: Options → Maintenance. Each periodic backup (with its date, time and number of categories and plugins) has a “Restore” button, and “Restore from backup” also takes you back to the state before the last save — which also lets you undo a restore.

Exporting settings

The “Export settings” button in Options saves a complete copy of all your data (categories, plugins, colors, everything) to a separate file with a date in its name. You can later move it to another computer or keep it as an extra backup.

Importing settings

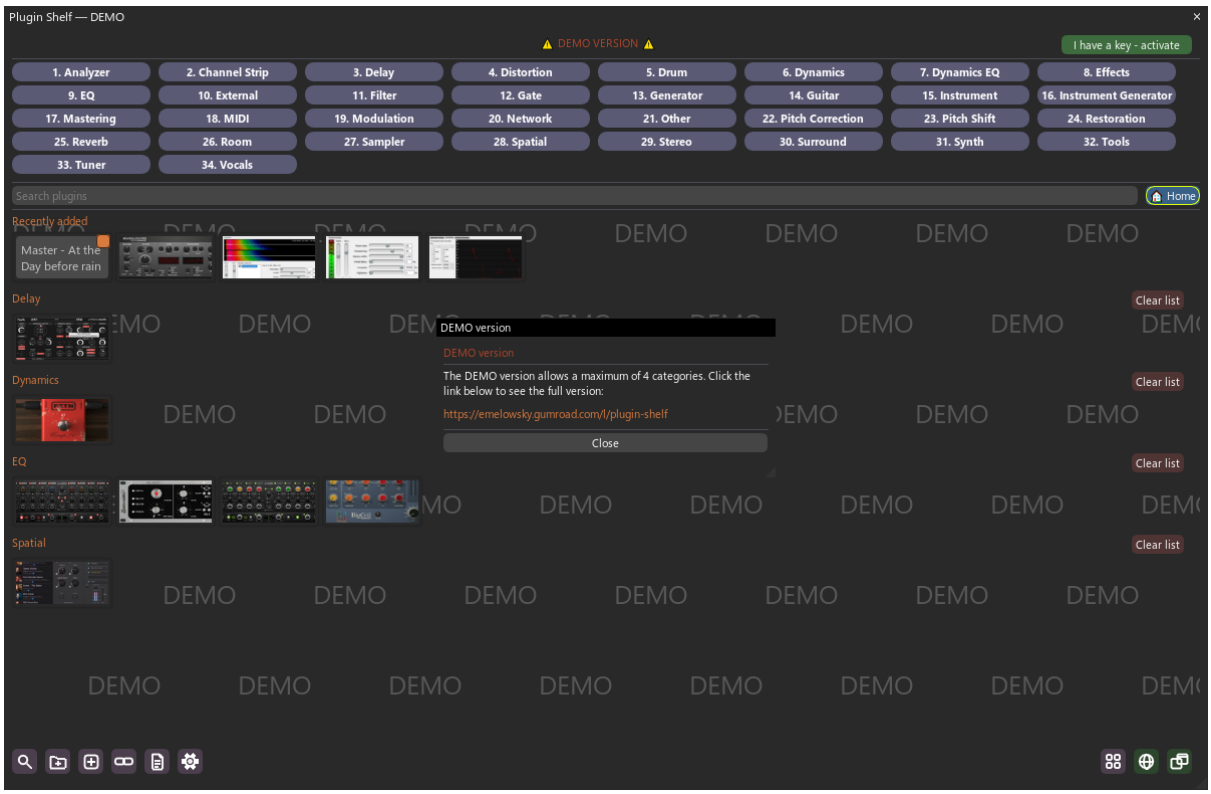
The “Import settings” button loads a previously exported file. WARNING: importing OVERWRITES your entire current configuration — a confirmation window always appears before importing, and your current state will still be automatically backed up first.

16. Demo version — limitations

Until a license is activated, Plugin Shelf runs in demo mode — fully functional; the only differences from the full version are:

- A limit of 4 categories
- A limit of 5 plugins per category
- The Options panel is visible but locked — nothing can be changed except the language
- A clear DEMO label in the window title
- The automatic categories wizard adds plugins only within these limits

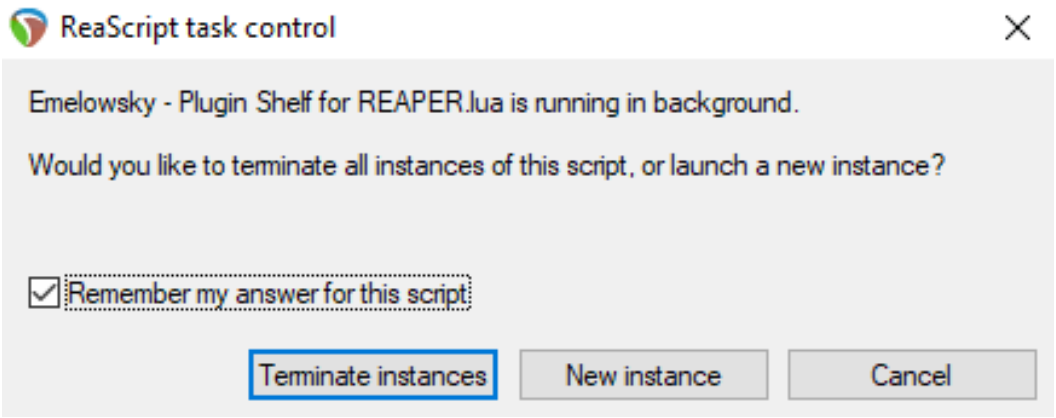
Once you hit the limit, you'll see a message with a link to purchase the full version. After you activate a license (chapter 2), the limits disappear immediately — there's no other version of the script to install, and everything you set up in demo mode stays.



17. Troubleshooting

The ON/OFF shortcut doesn't work when the Plugin Shelf window has focus

Check that in the shortcut settings (Edit Shortcut), the Scope field is set to “Global + text fields” — see chapter 13. The first time you trigger closing it, the script will let you know it'll keep running in the background. Just check ***Remember my answer for this script*** and click ***Terminate instances***



A freshly created folder in the Chains tab doesn't show up

The script refreshes the list automatically after every folder operation — if you still don't see something, click “Refresh” in the panel.

The license key doesn't work

Check that you pasted the ENTIRE key (the whole block, with nothing cut off at the start or end), and that the email address in the activation field is exactly the same as at the time of purchase.

I changed computers / reinstalled my system — the license doesn't work

The Machine ID changes along with your hardware/system. Move your license to the new Machine ID with “Open customer panel” — see chapter 2, “Moving your license to another computer”.

I renamed an icon file in the folder — the plugin lost its picture

This is expected, safe behavior — if the icon file disappears from disk (e.g. you renamed it), the tile automatically falls back to the text version (plugin name instead of a picture) instead of showing an error. To restore the icon, open Edit plugin properties and point it to the file under its new name — or click “Fill in icons” in the automatic categories wizard (chapter 4b), and the script will match icons for all such tiles.

A tile didn't get an icon even though the icon is in the folder

The icon file name differs from the plugin name in REAPER. Rename the file following the rule in chapter 5 (“Making your own icons”), then in Options → Maintenance → “Automatic categories…” click “Fill in icons”. You can also pick the icon manually in Edit plugin properties.

REAPER 6: the script doesn't start

On REAPER 6 run the script from the “Lua 5.3 (REAPER 6)” folder of the package — the files in the “Lua 5.4 (REAPER 7)” folder only work on REAPER 7. Older REAPER versions also lack some functions (e.g. listing installed plugins directly from REAPER) — Plugin Shelf then reads them from REAPER's settings files, but it works most comfortably on a current REAPER.

“Plugin Shelf is already running from another location”

Two copies of Plugin Shelf are installed in different folders (usually a manual copy in Scripts/Plugin Shelf for REAPER and the ReaPack copy in Scripts/Emelowsky/Plugin Shelf for REAPER), and one of them is already running. Keep one: close the other one, delete the old folder with its action and toolbar button, and restart REAPER. Your shelf data lives next to each copy (user_plugins_3.x.lua) — copy that file to the folder you keep while Plugin Shelf is closed.

Contact and reporting a problem

Write to emelowsky.plugins@gmail.com. Include the diagnostic info: Options > About > “Copy diagnostic info”, then paste it into your e-mail (Ctrl+V) — it contains your REAPER and extension versions and your Machine ID, so we can help you faster. All Emelowsky Plugins scripts, manuals and videos: emelowsky.com/plugins (also in Options → About).

The “What's new” window

After a script update, a window with the list of new features appears once. Close it with the Close button — it won't show up again on the next launches.